

English 6110: Marianne Moore and Elizabeth Bishop

Final Exam, Fall 2006

Before you begin, read through the entire exam. Choose a combination of questions that demonstrates the breadth as well as the depth of your knowledge. Read each question carefully, answer all parts of the question, organize your essay into coherent paragraphs, and support your answer with specific examples. Refer to secondary sources when appropriate. Take about 20% of the allotted time to plan each essay before you begin writing. The exam lasts from 6:00-7:50 p.m. Budget your time. If you are writing on a computer, allow time to print your exam within the allotted time.

Choose *two* of the following. Each essay is worth 50% and should take about 55 minutes.

1. One of the most striking similarities between Marianne Moore and Elizabeth Bishop is their attraction to animals as subjects for poetry. Referring to specific poems, analyze the use of animals in each poet's work. What are the potential benefits and pitfalls of examining Bishop's and Moore's animal poems together?
2. Characterize as precisely as you can Marianne Moore's and Elizabeth Bishop's personal and professional relationship with one another by drawing upon the poetry and prose of both writers. To what extent does understanding their relationship illuminate the work of one or both poets?
3. Although other women poets of the twentieth century have dealt more overtly with gender issues than have Marianne Moore and Elizabeth Bishop, is it worthwhile to examine their work in terms of gender? Or is it a distortion of their work to impose upon them a feminist agenda that they did not themselves emphasize or possibly endorse? Take a stand on the matter and support it with reference to specific poems and other works as applicable.
4. Make a case for the importance of reading and analyzing Elizabeth Bishop's letters. For example, are they primarily important as documents of literary history? How significant are they as literature in and of themselves? How useful are they in illuminating her poetry?
5. How does Marianne Moore situate herself as a critic and as a poet? To what extent do these roles intersect for her and to what extent do they differ? Make your case by referring to specific examples from her poetry and her critical prose.